

Pakistan's Security State

Nuclear Arsenal, ISI, and the Military's Permanent Hold on Power

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Executive Summary

Pakistan's security architecture is unique in the post-Cold War world: a nuclear-armed state governed in substance by its military establishment rather than its elected civilian governments, which shares a contested border with India (nuclear-armed, superior conventional forces), an ungoverned border with Afghanistan (Taliban-controlled since 2021), and a deep strategic partnership with China that is the nearest thing to a formal alliance Pakistan maintains. Pakistan possesses approximately 170 nuclear warheads (SIPRI 2026 estimate) — making it the world's 5th or 6th largest nuclear arsenal — and a delivery doctrine explicitly based on first-use against Indian conventional military superiority. The combination of nuclear arsenal, authoritarian military governance, Taliban frontier, and economic fragility makes Pakistan the most strategically complex and potentially dangerous state in South Asia.

The Army — formally the Pakistan Army, led since November 2022 by General Syed Asim Munir — exercises effective sovereignty over Pakistan's foreign policy, nuclear command and control, Afghanistan policy, and counter-terrorism strategy. Civilian governments (currently the PML-N coalition under PM Shehbaz Sharif, following the controversial February 2024 elections) administer economic policy, social services, and domestic governance within limits set by the military establishment. This civil-military structure — the "Deep State" that Pakistani civil society and international analysts describe — is not a recent aberration; it is the product of 75 years of institutional evolution in which the Army has intervened directly (coups in 1958, 1969, 1977, 1999) or indirectly (removing civilian governments through judicial action, intelligence pressure, and street protest management) whenever civilian governments threatened military prerogatives.

Part I — The Nuclear Dimension

The Arsenal and its Doctrine

Pakistan's nuclear programme — initiated secretly after India's 1974 "Smiling Buddha" nuclear test, accelerated after India's 1998 Pokhran-II tests — has produced an arsenal of approximately 170 warheads deliverable by ballistic missiles (Shaheen-III, Ghaznavi, Abdali series), cruise missiles (Babur series, Raad air-launched cruise missile), and aircraft (F-16 A/B, Mirage III/V equipped for nuclear delivery). Pakistan's nuclear posture is explicitly asymmetric: lacking the conventional military capability to withstand a sustained Indian military offensive, Pakistan relies on the threat of tactical nuclear weapons employment to deter Indian conventional operations, including limited strikes in response to terrorist attacks.

The Nasr (Hatf-9) system — a 60km-range surface-to-surface tactical nuclear missile first tested in 2011 — is the most provocative element of Pakistan's nuclear posture. Designed for "battlefield use" to destroy

an Indian armoured offensive crossing into Pakistani territory, Nasr compresses decision timelines in a crisis to minutes and raises serious questions about command and control during rapidly-escalating conventional conflict. India's nuclear doctrine of "no first use" combined with Pakistan's explicit first-use doctrine creates a deterrence asymmetry that makes nuclear risk in a crisis more significant than the bare arsenal numbers suggest.

Command and Control: The SPD

Pakistan's Strategic Plans Division (SPD) — the organisation responsible for nuclear command, control, and custody — is widely regarded by international analysts as a professionally managed organisation that maintains physical security of Pakistan's nuclear arsenal. The NCA (National Command Authority), nominally chaired by the Prime Minister, exercises formal authority over nuclear employment decisions, but in practice the Army Chief and SPD Director General are the operational decision-makers. The civilian Prime Minister's nuclear authority is real in theory and more circumscribed in practice — a structural reality in a state where the civilian government exists at military sufferance.

The most significant nuclear security concern: Pakistan's nuclear materials and warheads stored at multiple sites across a geographically diverse country with a Taliban insurgency in the northwest, Baloch separatist violence in the southwest, and sectarian militant groups (Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan, Lashkar-e-Taiba affiliated networks) operating in Punjab. The SPD's security protocols are designed for this threat environment — but the combination of a large dispersed arsenal, internal insurgent threats, and rapid warhead dispersal in a crisis creates nuclear security risks that are higher than in any other nuclear state.

Part II — The Taliban Frontier

Afghanistan's Taliban and the TTP Problem

The Taliban's return to power in Afghanistan (August 2021) has produced a profound security paradox for Pakistan: Pakistan's ISI played a key role in sustaining the Taliban through two decades of US occupation, and the Taliban victory was in one sense a Pakistani strategic success — removing a US-aligned government in Kabul and ending American military presence on Pakistan's western border. But the Taliban's return has simultaneously enabled a resurgence of the Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) — a distinct organisation from the Afghan Taliban but one that uses Afghan territory as a sanctuary for attacks inside Pakistan.

TTP attacks inside Pakistan surged after the Afghan Taliban takeover: 2022 saw a 50%+ increase in militant attacks inside Pakistan; 2023 saw further escalation including a suicide bombing at a Police Lines mosque in Peshawar killing 101 people (January 2023) — the deadliest single attack in Pakistan in years. The Pakistan Army's Operation Azm-e-Istehkam (launched 2024) targets TTP sanctuaries in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and tribal areas — the same strategy (military operations in tribal areas) that Pakistan has attempted multiple times since 2004 with limited durable success. The structural problem: Pakistan cannot convincingly demand the Afghan Taliban expel the TTP when the two organisations share ideological affinity and personnel networks, and when Pakistan lacks leverage over a Taliban government that no longer depends on Pakistani territory for its survival.

The Durand Line Dispute

The Durand Line — the 2,670 km Pakistan-Afghanistan border established by the British in 1893 — is disputed by the Afghan Taliban, which has never accepted the line's legitimacy as an international boundary. Pakistan's attempt to build a border fence along the Durand Line (approximately 90% complete as of 2026) has been physically attacked by Taliban border forces on multiple occasions. The Taliban-Pakistan relationship — which was supposed to be the strategic dividend of Pakistan's

decades-long ISI support — has produced not a compliant client state but a neighbour that disputes Pakistan's territorial integrity, hosts Pakistan's primary internal militant threat, and refuses to recognise the border that defines Pakistan's western frontier. The "strategic depth" in Afghanistan that successive Pakistan Army chiefs described as the rationale for ISI Taliban support has produced, in practice, strategic anxiety rather than strategic depth.

Part III — India-Pakistan: The Managed Hostility

Kashmir and the Line of Control

The India-Pakistan dispute over Kashmir — the cause of two full-scale wars (1947-48, 1965), one limited war (1999 Kargil), and continuous cross-LoC (Line of Control) militancy and infiltration — entered a new phase in August 2019 when India's Modi government abrogated Article 370 of India's Constitution, revoking Jammu and Kashmir's special autonomous status and reorganising it into two Union Territories directly administered by New Delhi. Pakistan condemned the move as a violation of UN Security Council resolutions and severed diplomatic and trade relations with India.

As of August 2026, the India-Pakistan diplomatic relationship remains at the lowest point since the 2001-2002 military standoff following the Indian Parliament attack: no high-commissioner-level ambassadors (only chargé d'affaires), no bilateral trade (officially zero since Pakistan's August 2019 suspension, though some informal trade continues via third countries), no SAARC summits (Pakistan has blocked SAARC meetings since the Uri attack of 2016), and no direct transport links. The ceasefire along the LoC agreed in February 2021 has held in terms of cross-border firing, but the structural hostility — Pakistani state sponsorship of Kashmiri militant groups, Indian intelligence counter-operations, and the unresolved territorial dispute — is unchanged.

The Nuclear Red Line

The most dangerous scenario in South Asian security — and the one that generates the most intensive US, Chinese, and international crisis management attention — is an escalation from terrorist attacks originating in Pakistan to Indian conventional military retaliation, which triggers Pakistani nuclear first use. The scenario has come uncomfortably close to reality twice: the 2001-2002 standoff (Operation Parakram, Indian mobilisation along the border) and the 2019 Balakot air strikes (India struck what it described as a JeM terrorist training camp inside Pakistan; Pakistan Air Force responded with an aerial counterattack; an Indian fighter pilot was captured; the crisis de-escalated over 48 hours). The 2019 Balakot episode demonstrated that nuclear-armed states can engage in limited air strikes without triggering nuclear escalation — but it also demonstrated how compressed the decision-making timeline is once kinetic operations begin.

Part IV — Pakistan's Strategic Choices

The China-US Balancing Act

Pakistan's strategic positioning has historically been shaped by the US relationship: Pakistani territory and intelligence cooperation enabled the 1980s anti-Soviet Afghan mujahedeen programme, the post-2001 Afghanistan operations logistics corridor (the Ground Lines of Communication through Pakistan were essential for the NATO resupply of Afghanistan), and intermittent counter-terrorism cooperation against al-Qaeda and affiliated groups. The US paid for this cooperation with arms transfers (\$7.5 billion in Pakistan security assistance 2002-2011), economic support, and tolerance of Pakistan's nuclear programme development and ISI's dual-game with Taliban.

The US-Pakistan relationship has deteriorated since the US withdrawal from Afghanistan (August 2021), which Pakistan's military calculated incorrectly as a permanent strategic rebalancing in its favour. US congressional sentiment toward Pakistan — particularly around ISI's sanctuary provision to groups targeting US forces in Afghanistan — has hardened; US security assistance has dropped dramatically; and Pakistan's strategic calculation has shifted more decisively toward China. The China-Pakistan relationship — described by both governments as "higher than the Himalayas, deeper than the ocean" — is now Pakistan's primary external strategic anchor, with CPEC as the economic manifestation and implied Chinese security assurance as the strategic backdrop.

Conclusion: The Stability Paradox

Pakistan's security architecture in 2026 presents a stability paradox: a nuclear-armed state with a competent army that is the primary source of both Pakistan's external deterrence and its domestic political dysfunction. The army's control of Pakistan's security prevents the kind of state collapse that would make nuclear weapons truly unsafe; the same control prevents the political normalisation and economic reform that Pakistan's development requires. The army that keeps Pakistan stable also keeps it dysfunctional.

South Asia's security architecture cannot be understood without integrating Pakistan's nuclear arsenal, its Taliban frontier, its India enmity, and its China dependency as a coherent system — each element reinforcing the others, each making the others harder to resolve. The nuclear deterrent makes India reluctant to compel Pakistan to act against militants; the India enmity justifies the army's domestic political dominance; the army's dominance perpetuates the economic weakness that drives reliance on China; the China relationship reinforces the India enmity. Pakistan's security dilemma is not one problem — it is a system of interlocking problems that no single intervention can unravel.

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All data from SIPRI, RAND, ICG, FAS, UN Security Council Reports, and cited sources.